



SPAIN & VALENCIA

GOVERNMENT GUIDE

How power works. Who runs what. The gritty reality.

Valencia at the centre · March 2026

PM: Pedro Sanchez (PSOE) | Regional: Juanfran Perez Llorca (PP) | Mayor of Valencia: Maria Jose Catala (PP)

PART 1 — HOW SPAIN IS GOVERNED

The three layers of power and what each controls

Spain is a parliamentary constitutional monarchy. Real power is split across three tiers: national, regional, and local. For someone living in Valencia, all three affect daily life — but in very different ways. Understanding which level controls what is the single most useful thing you can take from this document.

“Spain is ranked 2nd in the world for decentralised regional authority. Only Germany is more devolved.” —
Regional Authority Index

17	8,131	47M	5.1M
Autonomous Regions	Municipalities	National Population	Valencian Community

LEVEL	ROLE · PERSON · PARTY	SALARY
LEVEL 1 National / Madrid	Prime Minister PSOE — Left <i>Pedro Sanchez</i> Controls: defence, courts, immigration, national tax, pensions, foreign policy, national railways, state pension	€90,010 gross / year
LEVEL 2 Valencian Region	President of the Generalitat PP + Vox — Right <i>Juanfran Perez Llorca (since Nov 2025)</i> Controls: hospitals, schools, regional roads, housing policy, social care, regional police — the tier that most affects daily life	€91,398 gross / year
LEVEL 3 Valencia City	Mayor (Alcaldesa) PP + Vox — Right <i>Maria Jose Catala (since June 2023)</i> Controls: local planning, city buses, parks, local police, rubbish collection, urban development licences, local events	€94,000 gross / year

THE KING'S ROLE

The King? King Felipe VI earns €290,000 but has zero governing power. He is a constitutional head of state who signs laws (he must sign them — he cannot refuse), formally appoints the PM after elections, and represents Spain on the world stage. His role was deliberately made ceremonial as a safeguard after Franco's dictatorship ended in 1975.

PART 2 — WHO CONTROLS WHAT

The definitive breakdown — so you can complain to the right person

The most common mistake: complaining to the mayor about hospitals, or expecting the PM to fix your street. Here is the definitive map of who does what.

AREA	NATIONAL (Madrid)	REGIONAL (Valencia)	CITY (Valencia City)
Hospitals & public health	✓	✓	✗
Schools & universities	Framework	✓	✗
Income tax & VAT	✓	Partial	✗
National roads & motorways	✓	✗	✗
Local streets & city roads	✗	✗	✓
Guardia Civil / national police	✓	✗	✗
Local police (Policia Local)	✗	✗	✓
Planning permission (buildings)	✗	✗	✓
Social care & benefits	Framework	✓	✗
Public transport	✗	Metro/FGV	EMT buses
Courts & justice	✓	✗	✗
Immigration & borders	✓	✗	✗
Rubbish, parks, local permits	✗	✗	✓
Foreign policy & defence	✓	✗	✗
Flood / disaster response	Coord.	PRIMARY	Support

QUICK GUIDE

Key takeaway: If it involves your health, your child's school, or social services — your issue is with the Regional President (Perez Llorca). If it's about your street, your bins, or a building permit — it's the Mayor (Catala). If it's about immigration, courts, or big national infrastructure — it's Sanchez in Madrid.

PART 3 — THE MAIN PARTIES

Who they are, what they stand for, and why it matters in Valencia

PARTY	WHO THEY ARE	POSITION	IN POWER?	VALENCIAN RELEVANCE
PP	People's Party. Centre-right, mainstream conservative. Founded post-Franco.	Centre-Right	Valencia city + region	YOUR local government right now
PSOE	Spanish Socialist Workers' Party. Sánchez's party. Social-democrat tradition.	Centre-Left	National govt	Controls national budget & policy
Vox	Far-right nationalist. Anti-immigration, pro-Spanish unity, anti-autonomy.	Far-Right	Supports PP in Valencia	Rising post-DANA. Pulls PP rightward.
Compromís	Valencian regionalist-green coalition. Strong local roots and identity.	Left / Green	Opposition (Valencia)	Largest local opposition. Very vocal.
Sumar	Far-left coalition (successor to Podemos). Sánchez's coalition junior partner.	Far-Left	National coalition	Keeps Sanchez's govt alive
Junts	Catalan separatist party. Pragmatic, right-leaning. Unpredictable swing vote.	Catalan-Right	National swing vote	Wild card. Withdrew support Oct 2025.

ALLIANCE THE PP + VOX ARRANGEMENT IN VALENCIA

In Valencia city and region, PP governs with Vox's support. Nationally, they are electoral rivals competing for the same right-wing voter base. This creates a structural tension: they need each other locally while undercutting each other in national polls.

Vox pushes PP rightward on immigration and identity issues in exchange for coalition support. After the DANA disaster, Vox capitalised heavily on PP's weakness — post-2025 polls show Vox gaining directly at PP's expense in the Valencia region.

This arrangement is fragile. In 2024, Vox deliberately collapsed PP-Vox regional governments in Extremadura and Aragon over a migrant distribution dispute, forcing snap elections. The same could happen in Valencia if Vox chooses to pull the plug.

PART 4 — HOW ELECTIONS WORK

You vote for a list, not a person — here is how the system actually works

The most important thing to understand: you never directly elect a Prime Minister, a Regional President, or a Mayor in Spain. You vote for a party, and from there politicians elect each other. This concentrates enormous power inside party structures.

1

Join a Party

Spain's system is built around parties, not individuals. To have any real shot at office, you need to be on a party's electoral list. Independents can run — they very rarely win. The party provides funding, infrastructure, and name recognition.

2

Get Placed on the List

Parties use closed lists — the order is decided internally by party leadership. Position 1 almost always wins a seat. Position 20 might not. Internal party politics matter more than public popularity. This makes party loyalty essential.

3

The Vote Happens

Spanish voters pick a party, not a person. Seats are then distributed proportionally using the D'Hondt method, which slightly advantages larger parties. Rarely does one party win an outright majority. Expect coalition arithmetic.

4

Coalitions Form

After counting, parties negotiate. This is where real power is decided behind closed doors. PP needed Vox to govern Valencia. Sánchez needs Catalan separatists and others to govern Spain. These deals define all policy.

5

Parliament Elects the Leader

The Mayor is elected by city councillors — not the public directly. The Regional President is elected by regional parliament. You never vote for either of these roles personally. You only vote for a party list and trust the maths.

THE D'HONDT METHOD WHY SMALL PARTIES STRUGGLE TO BREAK THROUGH

Spain uses proportional representation with the D'Hondt counting method, which slightly advantages larger parties. A party winning 10% of votes might get 8% of seats, while the biggest party receives a small seat bonus.

This is why Vox (14-16% nationally) holds significant power — they control a block of seats that PP needs — but also why genuinely new parties struggle to gain a foothold. The system rewards established parties.

Each region is its own electoral district. Valencia has three provinces (Valencia, Alicante, Castellon), each electing seats to the Corts Valencianes (99 total). The city of Valencia elects councillors to the Ayuntamiento in a separate local election.

ROLE	ANNUAL GROSS	CONTEXT
King Felipe VI	€290,000	Head of State. Zero governing power.
President of Congress (Speaker)	€230,931	Highest paid elected official in Spain
Mayor of Valencia — Catala	€94,000	More than the PM — legally permitted
Regional President — Perez Llorca	€91,398	Controls hospitals, schools, social care
Prime Minister — Sanchez	€90,010	Among the lowest PM salaries in Europe
National Cabinet Minister	€76,355	
Spanish MP (base salary)	~€53,200	+ up to €1,921/month living allowance
Macron (France) — for comparison	€182,400	Europe benchmark
Average Spanish worker	€25,165	The reality for most people

PART 5 — KEY EVENTS TIMELINE

The political story that brought us to where we are today

To understand Spain's current political situation, you need this sequence of events. They explain why politics is so tense, why Valencia feels the way it does, and what is likely to happen next.

2018	Pedro Sanchez becomes PM via motion of no-confidence against Rajoy (PP). Ends 7 years of PP national government. Forms Spain's first coalition since the Second Republic.
May 2023	PP sweeps local elections across Spain. Maria Jose Catala (PP) elected Mayor of Valencia city. PP takes the Valencia region under Carlos Mazon with Vox coalition support.
Jul 2023	Spanish general election. Sánchez's PSOE outperforms polls. PP + Vox fall short of a national majority. Sánchez stays as PM via a complex, fragile multi-party coalition including Catalan separatists.
Oct 2024	DANA flash flooding devastates the Valencia region. 220+ people killed — Spain's deadliest natural disaster in modern history. Regional President Mazon later revealed to have been at a 3-hour lunch when alerts peaked. Warnings to residents came too late.
Oct 2025	Junts (Catalan separatists) withdraws support from Sanchez's national government. Sanchez survives a motion of no-confidence by a narrow margin. Spain's political paralysis deepens. No national budget since 2023.
Nov 2025	Carlos Mazon resigns as Regional President after being publicly jeered at a DANA memorial by victims' families. Juanfran Perez Llorca elected as replacement by the regional parliament, narrowly avoiding snap elections.
Mar 2026	Current state: Valencia governed by PP + Vox at city and regional level. Spain governed by Sanchez (PSOE) minority coalition. Both national and Valencia regional elections expected in 2027.

Next scheduled elections: national, regional (Valencia), and city. Valencia could trigger early regional election if the PP coalition fractures. Sanchez has stated his intention to govern until 2027.

PART 6 — THE GRITTY REALITIES

Six things that define Spanish and Valencian politics right now

THE DANA DISASTER SPAIN'S DEFINING RECENT CRISIS

On 29 October 2024, catastrophic flash flooding (DANA) struck the Valencia region. Over 220 people died — the deadliest natural disaster in Spain in modern history. Many victims were trapped in cars in underground car parks as water surged through tunnels and underpasses.

The scandal was not only the flood itself, but the response. Regional President Carlos Mazon was at a three-hour business lunch when emergency alerts were at their peak. Official warnings to residents came too late — some received the alert after water was already inside their homes.

King Felipe VI and Mazon attended a memorial in Paiporta. They were confronted by hundreds of relatives of victims who threw mud and sticks and chanted abuse directly at them. The images were broadcast globally. Mazon resigned on 3 November 2025 after new evidence confirmed his inaction.

Political fallout continues. Criminal investigations are ongoing into who knew what and when. Vox has capitalised. Sanchez used the disaster politically, pointing to PP regional failures. For Valencians, DANA is not just a weather event — it is a symbol of how the political class failed ordinary people.

NATIONAL GRIDLOCK GOVERNING SPAIN WITHOUT A MAJORITY

Pedro Sanchez has governed Spain without a parliamentary majority since 2018. He requires support from seven or eight different parties — including Catalan separatists, Basque nationalists, and far-left parties — to pass anything in parliament.

Spain's last national budget was passed in 2023 and has been automatically extended ever since. No new budget. No new fiscal priorities. The government governs by executive decree and emergency measures, which limits what it can actually deliver.

In October 2025, Junts (the main Catalan separatist party) withdrew their support. Sanchez survived a motion of no-confidence by just a handful of votes. His coalition is held together by deal-making, concessions, and the arithmetic fact that PP cannot themselves assemble a majority to replace him.

Sanchez has announced his intention to govern until the scheduled 2027 elections. Whether he survives depends entirely on which parties need what from him at any given moment — an inherently unstable dynamic that produces constant political theatre.

VALENCIA'S FUNDING PROBLEM THE STRUCTURAL INJUSTICE EVERYONE TALKS ABOUT

Spain's 17 regions have wildly different fiscal arrangements. The Basque Country and Navarra collect their own income and corporate taxes and retain far more of what they raise — a legacy of 19th century historical agreements (fueros) that have nothing to do with economic logic.

Valencia contributes significantly to the national tax pool but receives proportionally less back per capita than the Basque Country, Navarra, or Madrid. Per capita public spending in Valencia is consistently lower than in these regions, despite similar or higher tax contributions per resident.

This structurally underfunds Valencian hospitals, infrastructure, and schools relative to what locals pay in. It is embedded in the constitution and requires broad national consensus to change — something Spain's fragmented parliament makes essentially impossible to achieve.

Every Valencian politician of every stripe invokes this grievance. Compromis has built a significant portion of its platform around it. Even PP politicians raise it loudly with Madrid — then find themselves in the national coalition that perpetuates it. The hypocrisy is not lost on voters.

THE CORRUPTION PROBLEM BOTH MAIN PARTIES, DIFFERENT SCANDALS

Spanish politics has a deep and cross-party corruption problem. Voter fatigue is real and measurable — most Spaniards have internalised low expectations of politicians across the board, which paradoxically makes accountability harder to enforce.

PP's defining scandal was Gurtel: a systematic network of kickbacks to PP officials in exchange for public contracts, originating largely in the Valencia region during the 2000s. It reached senior party figures and directly contributed to PM Rajoy's removal via motion of no confidence in 2018.

PSOE's current scandal is the Koldo Case: former Transport Minister Jose Luis Abalos is accused of accepting bribes in exchange for pandemic-era PPE contracts. PSOE's party organisation secretary Santos Cerdan resigned over related allegations in 2025.

Locally: Valencia's Mayor Catala has refused to disclose what she earned teaching at a private university (Universidad Internacional de Valencia) while serving as mayor. Several PP and Vox council members have separately been accused of claiming exclusive dedication salaries while holding additional paid positions.

THE CATALAN QUESTION AND WHY VALENCIANS WATCH IT WITH PARTICULAR RESENTMENT

Catalan separatism is Spain's most intractable political fault line. After a 2017 illegal independence referendum and the jailing of Catalan leaders, Sanchez controversially granted pardons in 2021 and has since made additional autonomy concessions in exchange for Catalan parliamentary support.

For Valencians, the Catalan issue carries a specific resentment beyond the national debate: Catalans have fiscal arrangements (concert economico equivalent) that Valencia does not. Watching Madrid grant concessions to Catalonia while Valencia remains structurally underfunded creates a distinctly local anger.

The Valencian language question adds another dimension. Valencian and Catalan are linguistically very close — a source of ongoing political and cultural debate. Compromis champions Valencian linguistic identity; PP has been more cautious; Vox opposes all regional language promotion as a threat to Spanish unity.

PUBLIC TRUST IN POLITICIANS THE HONEST PICTURE — AND WHY IT MATTERS

Trust in Spain's political institutions is chronically low. Annual surveys consistently show politicians and political parties ranking among Spaniards' top concerns — not as important issues, but as a problem in themselves. The political class is seen as self-serving and disconnected.

Corruption, perceived self-interest, and constant coalition brinksmanship have generated a deep cynicism, particularly among younger Spaniards. Abstention is rising. In Valencia after DANA, many voters feel every party failed them in some way — right for governing badly, left for politicising grief.

Despite this, Spain's democracy functions. Governments change. Courts prosecute politicians (including former PM Rajoy's party). Press freedom is strong and investigative journalism is active. The gap is between formal institutional quality and public faith in the individuals running those institutions.

One striking local data point: in Valencia, debates about Valencia CF (the football club's governance and ownership under Peter Lim) consistently attract more public anger and civic engagement than many ward-level political issues. Institutional politics has lost the emotional connection that sport still holds.

PART 7 — PUBLIC PERCEPTION

How Spaniards and Valencians actually see their government

Understanding the political structure is one thing. Understanding how people actually feel — the social and cultural texture of politics, the resentments, the cynicism, and the occasional pride — is another. Here is a realistic picture.

TOPIC	NATIONAL MOOD	VALENCIAN VIEW	THE REALITY
Sanchez & his government	Deeply polarised. Left see a pragmatic survivor; right see a PM clinging to power via separatist deals at any cost.	Mixed. DANA resentment is real, but anti-PP feeling keeps left voters loyal. Many feel abandoned.	Minority govt, no budget since 2023. Governing via deal-making. Every confidence vote is a crisis.
The monarchy	Quietly accepted by most. Republican sentiment concentrated on the left and in Catalonia. Not a dominant issue.	Felipe VI was booed and pelted with mud at the DANA memorial in Païporta. Seen as distant and out of touch.	Constitutionally untouchable. Republican sentiment is growing but remains a minority nationally.
The DANA floods	National shock. Pointed to as evidence of PP regional incompetence and underinvestment in emergency systems.	Visceral, personal anger. Hundreds of families directly lost relatives. Mazon became a symbol of elite negligence.	A defining political event reshaping Valencia's map. Vox gained. PP badly wounded. Investigations ongoing.
Immigration	Increasingly dominant issue. Vox and PP both hardening language. Canary Islands crisis dominating headlines.	Valencia receives Mediterranean boat arrivals. Viewed differently by urban progressives vs rural conservatives.	National competence only. Regions have no formal power, but local political pressure on PP from Vox is real.
Corruption	Voter fatigue. Both main parties have major scandals. Trust in politicians at historic lows across surveys.	Long memory: PP's Gurtel scandal originated here. PSOE's Koldo case more recent. All parties tainted.	Endemic. Transparency International ranks Spain 36th in EU. Mid-table is not reassuring.
Cost of living / housing	Top public concern. Rents rising sharply in cities. Young Spaniards locked out of ownership entirely.	Valencia cheaper than Madrid/Barcelona but rents have risen 30-40% since 2020. Visible pressure in city centre.	Limited government tools. Supply constraint is structural and planning reform is slow and contested.
Regional funding	Low salience nationally — viewed as a technical debate between regions and treasury.	MAJOR local issue. Valencians know they contribute more than they receive. It funds the Basque and Catalan deal.	Statistically correct: Valencia is underfunded relative to contribution. No political consensus to fix it.
Catalan independence	Divisive nationally. Many view Sanchez's pardons and concessions to Catalan parties as a betrayal of Spain.	Viewed with resentment specific to Valencia: Catalans get fiscal deals; Valencians get ignored despite same ask.	Sanchez granted pardons and autonomy concessions to Catalan leaders in exchange for political survival.

“When Valencia floods, trust in everyone sinks.” — Widely shared sentiment on Spanish social media, October 2024

WHY NATIONAL POLLS DON'T TELL THE WHOLE STORY

Important nuance: Spanish public opinion is highly regionalised. What people in Madrid think about Sanchez, what Valencians think about PP, what Catalans think about Spain — these are often entirely different conversations happening simultaneously. There is no single Spanish public opinion on most contested political questions.

PART 8 — QUICK REFERENCE

Everything you need to remember, in one place

QUESTION	ANSWER
Who runs Valencia city?	Mayor Maria Jose Catala (PP). Elected by councillors in June 2023. Next city election: 2027.
Who runs the Valencia region?	President Juanfran Perez Llorca (PP). In post since November 2025. PP + Vox coalition. Next regional election: 2027.
Who runs Spain?	PM Pedro Sanchez (PSOE). In office since 2018. Minority government relying on multiple small parties. Next national election: 2027.
Who is the head of state?	King Felipe VI. Ceremonial only — signs laws, appoints PM, represents Spain abroad. Zero policy power. Salary: €290,000.
Can I vote in Valencia as an EU resident?	Yes — in city (local) elections only. Not in regional or national elections. You must be registered on the padron municipal.
Why does the Mayor earn more than the PM?	Mayoral salaries are set locally by each city council based on population. Valencia City has set its rate at €94,000. No rule prevents it being higher than the PM's nationally-set salary.
Who controls the hospital I use?	The regional government (Generalitat Valenciana). Not the city, not Madrid. The region runs the entire public health system.
Who controls local schools?	The regional government controls funding, staffing, and curriculum for all public schools. The city has no jurisdiction.
What was DANA?	October 2024 flash floods that killed 220+ people in Valencia region. Spain's deadliest modern natural disaster. Defined regional politics for years. Regional President Mazon resigned over his handling of it.
Why is Valencia underfunded?	Valencia contributes significantly to national taxes but receives less back per capita than the Basque Country or Navarra, who have special fiscal arrangements. A structural injustice with no politically feasible fix in sight.
What is Vox?	Spain's main far-right party. Hard on immigration, strongly pro-Spanish unity (anti-regional autonomy). Currently supporting PP in Valencia. Growing in polls post-DANA as PP weakens.
What is Compromis?	A left-of-centre Valencian regionalist coalition. Pro-environment, pro-Valencian identity. Currently the main opposition in Valencia city and region. Very vocal on funding injustice.
Is Spain politically stable?	No. Sanchez has governed without a majority since 2018. No budget since 2023. Coalition deals with separatists cause constant controversy. 2027 elections will be decisive for the next decade.
When are the next elections?	National: due 2027. Valencia region: expected 2027 (could be earlier if coalition fractures). Valencia city: 2027.